

GAZA RIVIERA
SOLUTION OR SACRILEGE?

CONFLICTING VISIONS OF PEACE

Two contrasting perspectives on Donald Trump's grand plan for Gaza emerged at the India Today Conclave 2025. Dr Zeina Jallad, director, Palestine Land Studies Center, fiercely criticised Trump's proposal to rebuild Gaza and resettle its inhabitants in Jordan and Egypt. She labelled it a modern echo of the 1917 Balfour Declaration that partitioned West Asia amongst imperial France and Britain, accusing Trump of orchestrating a forced expulsion that commercialises Palestinian land into a 'riviera' while ignoring their rights and violating Palestinian sovereignty. She also denounced western stereotypes portraying Palestinians as barbaric, emphasising their dehumanisation and their sufferings at the hands of a vengeful Israel. In contrast, former Israeli MP Einat Wilf endorsed Trump's vision, arguing Gaza's natural assets—its Mediterranean shores and fertile soil—could transform it into a "Dubai of the Mediterranean". She blamed Palestinians for turning Gaza into a "weaponised landscape" with tunnels instead of skyscrapers. Wilf also defended Israel's continuing rejection of a two-state solution, claiming Palestinians consistently reject peace offers and opt for violence.

The session highlighted the deep ideological divide over Gaza's future—one side deplores forced displacement, the other sees an economic opportunity. Meanwhile, Arab leaders, led by Egypt's $53 billion reconstruction plan, have rejected Trump's displacement vision at a summit in Cairo, favouring the reconstruction of Gaza. ■



DR ZEINA JALLAD
Director, Palestine Land Studies Center; Assistant Professor of International Law, American University of Beirut

Trump is snatching the Palestinians' right to live, commercialising everything to a Riviera. Palestinians have the potential to build their own Riviera... But how do we create a normal condition for them to live?

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**



EINAT WILF
Author & former Member of Parliament, Israel

Gaza can be the Dubai of the Mediterranean. It has all that's needed to become a pearl of the Mediterranean

If you attack a country there will be consequences. The October 7 attack was planned over decades